New Limits on Chinese Drones Leave Police Facing Higher Costs

From: NPR World Mined: 2026-10-12 5 min read

Police departments across the United States use **drones**, which are small flying machines with cameras, for many jobs. They help with search and rescue, fire and traffic crash investigations, and watching over big crowds. About 6,000 **law enforcement** agencies now have **drones**, according to the **Law Enforcement** Drone Association, a group that trains police to use them.

Most of those **drones** come from DJI, a company in China. The association estimates that about 80% to 90% of police drone programs use DJI devices.

The Trump administration wants to change that and help American drone makers. It has banned many new foreign-made **drones** from the U.S. market and announced **tariffs**, or extra taxes, of 15% to 100% on some foreign **drones**. The administration says Chinese **drones** could be a **national security** threat. DJI denies that its products share data with the Chinese government.

Many police leaders worry about the cost. In Ocean County, New Jersey, the sheriff's office has a fleet of 25 DJI **drones**. In July, it used a drone to drop **flotation devices** to two swimmers in trouble, and rescuers brought them to shore. Kevin Fennessy, who leads the program, says American **drones** are good but cost about three times as much.

NPR compared two similar **drones**. A Chinese DJI model sells for about $10,500, while an American-made one costs about $21,000.

Some states, including Florida and Texas, have banned police from using foreign **drones**, and some departments had to end their drone programs. A national sheriffs' group has asked federal **regulators** to allow an exception until American companies can make enough **drones**.

An American drone company leader says this is a chance to build more **drones** in the U.S. Fennessy says that if police must switch, "the funding's got to be there."

Word Treasure

drones -- Small aircraft that fly without a pilot on board and are controlled from the ground.
law enforcement -- Police and other officers whose job is to make sure laws are followed.
tariffs -- Taxes a country charges on goods brought in from other countries.
national security -- Keeping a country and its people safe from threats.
flotation devices -- Objects that float and help keep a person above water.
regulators -- Government officials who make and enforce rules for an industry.

Background you need

Drones are flying machines with cameras that police use to search for missing people, study crash scenes and help with rescues.

A Chinese company, DJI, makes most of the drones used by American police because they are capable and cost less.

The U.S. government worries that technology made in China could create security risks, so it is limiting some foreign drones to boost American makers.

Police departments pay for equipment from limited budgets, so higher prices can make it harder for them to keep their drone programs.

Break it down

LEAD: New U.S. limits on Chinese drones raise costs for police
KEY EVENT: Bans on many new foreign drones and tariffs of 15% to 100%
+- WHO: Trump administration, police departments, DJI
+- WHY: Government says Chinese drones may be a national security threat
EVIDENCE: 80% to 90% of police drone programs use DJI; price comparison of $10,500 vs. $21,000
EXAMPLE: Ocean County, New Jersey, uses drones for water rescues
RESPONSE: Some states banned foreign drones; sheriffs ask for an exception
OPEN QUESTION: Who will pay if police must switch to American drones?

Why it matters

Drones help police find missing people and save swimmers, so rules about them affect public safety. The debate shows how national security concerns and local budgets can pull in different directions.

Test what you remember

1. About how many U.S. law enforcement agencies have drones?

- (A) About 6,000
- (B) About 60
- (C) About 600
- (D) About 60,000

2. Which company makes most police drones in the U.S., according to the association?

- (A) DJI
- (B) Inspired Flight
- (C) Birdstop
- (D) NASA

3. What has the Trump administration done to help American drone makers?

- (A) Banned many new foreign drones and added tariffs
- (B) Moved DJI to America
- (C) Banned all drones in the U.S.
- (D) Given every police department free drones

4. How did Ocean County police use a drone in July?

- (A) To race other drones
- (B) To film a movie
- (C) To deliver mail
- (D) To drop flotation devices to two swimmers

5. In NPR's comparison, how much did the American-made drone cost?

- (A) About $1,000
- (B) About $100,000
- (C) About $10,500
- (D) About $21,000

6. What did a national sheriffs' group ask regulators to do?

- (A) Allow an exception until American companies can make enough drones
- (B) Raise tariffs higher
- (C) Buy only Chinese drones
- (D) Ban police drones

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: A 3: A 4: D 5: D 6: A

Questions to think about

1. Trump administration: Says Chinese drones could be a national security threat and wants to help American drone makers.
2. DJI: Denies that its products share data with the Chinese government.
3. Kevin Fennessy, Ocean County drone program: Says American drones are good but cost about three times as much, and funding must be provided if police must switch.
4. American drone company leader: Sees the limits as a chance to build more drones in the U.S.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):